Assignment 1 – Good and Bad User Interface Design

1. Good User Interface Design – QWERTY Keyboard

Objective of the Interface

- The main purpose of a keyboard is to allow users to enter text, numbers, and commands into a computer quickly and accurately.

Good Design Aspects

- The QWERTY keyboard is a good example of a familiar and standardized user interface.
- Unlike an alphabetical keyboard, the letters are arranged in a specific layout. This layout originated from mechanical typewriters and has remained widely used for many years.
- One of its main advantages is that users can learn touch typing, using all ten fingers without constantly looking at the keyboard.
- The keyboard also has a clear structure:
    - Frequently used keys are easy to recognize.
    - The F and J keys have small tactile marks to help users position their fingers.
    - Important keys, such as Enter, Space, Backspace, and Shift, are easy to identify.

Why Is It Good?

- Once users learn the layout, they can type quickly and efficiently without searching for individual letters.
- The standardized arrangement also makes it easier to switch between different computers because users do not need to learn a completely new layout.
- Although QWERTY is not necessarily the most efficient possible arrangement of letters, its familiarity and consistency make it a successful interface for experienced users.



2. Bad User Interface Design – Stairs for Skiers

Objective of the Interface

- The purpose of these stairs is to allow people to access the restrooms at a ski resort.

Bad Design Aspects

- The stairs are difficult and uncomfortable to use for skiers wearing ski boots.
- Ski boots are heavy, rigid, and designed primarily for skiing rather than walking. They limit ankle movement and make climbing or descending stairs more challenging.
- This creates several problems:
    - Walking down the stairs is uncomfortable and requires extra effort.
    - There is a greater risk of slipping or falling.
    - The interface does not consider the physical limitations of its main users.

Why Is It Bad?

- This is an example of a design that does not consider the context in which it will be used.
- At a ski resort, it is predictable that most visitors will be wearing ski boots. Therefore, the access to essential facilities should be adapted to their needs.
- The stairs may work perfectly well for people wearing normal shoes, but they are not an ideal solution for skiers.

Why Was It Designed This Way?

- The restrooms were probably placed on a lower floor to save space or because of the existing building structure.
- Traditional stairs may also have been a cheaper and simpler solution than designing a more accessible entrance.

Suggested Improvements

- A better design could include:
    - A gently sloped ramp with a non-slip surface.
    - An elevator or another accessible route to the restrooms.
    - Wider steps with anti-slip materials and sturdy handrails.
    - Restrooms located on the same floor as the main skiing area.
- These improvements would make the facilities safer, more comfortable, and easier to use.


Restrooms
Every skier's worst nightmare...